Altogether 110 interviews were conducted. Though not all of them have been quoted, every interview was critical in guiding the analysis and argument of this book. A subset of the larger pool of policy participants involved in Afghanistan, these interviews and interviewees are diverse enough to allow appreciation for different facets of India's Afghanistan policy, and to accommodate a variety of diverging opinions on this issue. Despite the imperfection of interviewing as a research methodology that often eludes objectivity, interviews are often the only way to know more about contemporary issues. Getting to the bottom of a topic and crosschecking facts, then, is the researcher's responsibility. On South Asia, such primary material remains relatively scarce. As most of these interviews were conducted as part of the author's doctoral project, a series of ethical clearances were required before setting off to the field, and were strictly adhered to. This means, in some cases, the identity of the interviewee has not been disclosed. Instead, rather unimaginatively, letters are used to denote them. In other cases, with consent of the interviewee, his/her identity has been disclosed. Information collected in all these different interviews was triangulated to ensure authenticity of data.

Structure of the book

This book is divided into three parts: debating neutrality, debating containment, and debating engagement. Each part deals with three different phases of India's role in Afghanistan. The first part, debating neutrality, consists of two chapters that examine the history of India's relations with Afghanistan and how the latter figures in the former's popular imagination. Elucidated in the second chapter, 'Kabuliwallah', this historical context helps in grounding the survey and argument of the book. By highlighting the cultural bonds between the two countries and its people, their relations across empires, and the state of bilateral relations between 1947 and 1979 (when the Soviet Union militarily invaded Afghanistan), the chapter teases out the evolution of the three drivers of India's foreign policy towards Afghanistan. The third chapter, 'Leaning Tower of Delhi', then details the impact that Moscow's military intervention in and withdrawal from Afghanistan had on India's Afghanistan policy debates. This was the first